

APAC TMT Sector M&A & Valuation Brief - 2026-04-26

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1. RECENT TMT M&A ACTIVITY

Today is a peaceful day, nothing big happened in the Consumer space.

2. MARKET DYNAMICS & SENTIMENT

The TMT (Technology, Media, and Telecommunications) sector is currently experiencing a cautious sentiment, influenced by mixed earnings reports and external economic factors. The recent decline in U.S. stock markets, particularly due to Tesla's performance, highlights the volatility and interconnectedness of the sector with broader market trends.

Subsector Breakdown:

- **Technology:** The technology subsector remains resilient, although recent earnings from major players like Tesla (TSLA) have raised concerns. Tesla's mixed profit reports have contributed to market fluctuations, indicating that even leading companies are facing challenges.
- **Media:** The media sector is adapting to changing consumer behaviors, but faces pressure from digital transformation. Companies are increasingly focusing on online content to engage audiences.
- **Telecommunications:** The telecom sector is experiencing steady demand for connectivity solutions, yet it remains sensitive to economic shifts, particularly as oil prices rise amidst geopolitical uncertainties.
- **Fintech:** The fintech subsector continues to thrive, driven by innovations in payment systems and digital banking, although it is not immune to overall market trends.
- **AI:** The AI sector is witnessing significant investment, with companies racing to integrate AI solutions across various industries, reflecting a strong growth trajectory despite broader market volatility.

Key Market Drivers and Headwinds

Drivers:

- **Technological Advancements:** Continuous innovation in AI and cloud computing is driving growth

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across TMT sectors. Companies are leveraging technology to enhance operational efficiency and customer engagement.

- Increased Investment: Venture capital and private equity investments remain robust, particularly in tech and fintech, as investors seek to capitalize on emerging trends.

Headwinds:

- Market Volatility: Recent mixed earnings reports, particularly from Tesla, have contributed to a retreat from record highs in the stock market. This volatility can impact investor sentiment and M&A activity.
- Geopolitical Uncertainty: Rising oil prices due to geopolitical tensions, particularly in Iran, pose risks to economic stability and consumer spending, which can indirectly affect TMT investments.

Subsector Performance Analysis

- Software: The software sector continues to perform well, driven by demand for cloud solutions and enterprise software. Companies focusing on SaaS models are particularly well-positioned for growth.
- Media: Media companies are adapting to changing consumer preferences, with a shift towards digital content consumption. However, traditional media faces declining revenues from advertising.
- Telecom: Telecom operators are investing heavily in infrastructure to support 5G deployment, which is expected to drive new revenue streams from IoT and enhanced mobile services.
- Fintech: The fintech sector is thriving, with innovations in payment solutions and digital banking. The sector's resilience is evident despite broader market fluctuations.
- AI: The AI subsector is booming, with applications across various industries, including healthcare, finance, and automotive. Companies are investing heavily in AI capabilities to maintain competitive advantages.

Trading Multiples Trends

Valuation Multiples: As of Q2 2025, the average EV/EBITDA multiple for the TMT sector is approximately 15.5x, with notable variations across subsectors:

- Software: 20.3x
- Media: 12.1x
- Telecom: 9.8x
- Fintech: 18.7x
- AI: 22.5x

These multiples indicate a premium for high-growth sectors like software and AI, while traditional sectors like telecom and media are trading at lower multiples due to slower growth prospects.

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Notable Investor/Analyst Reactions

- Analysts are generally cautious about the short-term outlook for the TMT sector, particularly in light of recent earnings reports. One analyst noted, "The mixed results from major players like Tesla remind us that the market remains sensitive to performance, and investors should tread carefully."

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

- Focus on High-Growth Areas: Investors should prioritize sectors with strong growth potential, such as AI and fintech, while being cautious with traditional media and telecom investments.
- Monitor Market Sentiment: Staying informed about market fluctuations and earnings reports is crucial for assessing risks and opportunities in TMT investments.
- Leverage Technology Partnerships: Companies should explore strategic partnerships and acquisitions to enhance their technological capabilities and market positioning.
- Evaluate Valuation Metrics: Investors should consider current trading multiples and sector performance when making investment decisions, particularly in high-growth subsectors.

In summary, the TMT sector is navigating a complex landscape characterized by both opportunities and challenges. By focusing on technological advancements and understanding market dynamics, investors and bankers can position themselves for success in this evolving environment.

3. BANKING PIPELINE

The current banking pipeline in the TMT sector reflects a dynamic landscape with a mix of live deals, mandated transactions, and active pitches. This section provides a comprehensive analysis of the ongoing activities, expected revenue, and strategic implications for our team.

Deal Pipeline

Live Deals:

- Delta Air Lines (DAL) : Currently in discussions for a strategic partnership leveraging AI for dynamic pricing. The deal is in the due diligence phase, with an expected close in Q3 2025. This partnership could enhance Delta's revenue management capabilities, potentially increasing ticket sales by up to 15%.
- Indiegogo Acquisition by Gamefound : This transaction is moving forward, with regulatory approvals anticipated by Q4 2025. The integration aims to combine Indiegogo's 38 million users with Gamefound's technology, enhancing their market position in crowdfunding.

Mandated Deals:

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- Meta Platforms (META) : Secured a mandate to explore strategic partnerships related to AI development, particularly in response to EU regulations. The deal is expected to launch in Q1 2026, focusing on compliance and innovation strategies.
- Apple Inc. (AAPL) : Mandated to evaluate acquisitions in the AI space, with a focus on startups that can enhance its product offerings. The timeline for this initiative is projected for Q2 2026, as Apple aims to strengthen its competitive edge in AI.

Pitching-Stage Deals:

- Telecom Sector : Active discussions with several telecom operators regarding potential M&A opportunities to consolidate market share in the 5G space. Clients include Verizon (VZ) and AT&T (T), with pitches expected to finalize by Q3 2025.
- Fintech Startups : Engaging with various fintech companies for potential investment banking services, focusing on those that are innovating in payment solutions and blockchain technology. Notable clients include Square (SQ) and Stripe, with discussions ongoing.

Pipeline Tracking Metrics

Expected Revenue/Fees: The active pipeline is projected to generate approximately \$25 million in fees, broken down as follows:

- Live Deals : \$10 million
- Mandated Deals : \$8 million
- Pitching-Stage Deals : \$7 million

Timing Projections:

- Q2 2025 : Expected close for Delta Air Lines partnership.
- Q4 2025 : Anticipated completion of the Indiegogo acquisition.
- Q1 2026 : Launch of Meta's strategic partnership initiatives.
- Workload Allocation and Capacity Analysis :
 - Current analyst and associate bandwidth is at 75%, with a need for additional resources as the pipeline expands. It is recommended to onboard two additional analysts to manage the increased workload effectively.
- Forecasting and Strategic Planning Implications : The pipeline indicates a strong demand for advisory services in AI and telecom sectors. Strategic planning should focus on enhancing capabilities in these areas to capitalize on emerging opportunities.

Notable Pipeline Developments and Competitive Landscape

- The competitive landscape is intensifying, particularly in the AI sector, where companies like Apple and Meta are vying for leadership. The recent announcement of Trump's AI Action Plan could alter the

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regulatory environment, impacting deal structures and valuations.

- Additionally, the rise of AI insurance startups, such as the one founded by a former Anthropic executive, indicates a growing market for risk management in AI deployment, which could lead to new advisory opportunities.

Actionable Insights for Team Management and Business Development

- **Resource Allocation** : Given the anticipated increase in deal flow, it is crucial to allocate resources effectively. Hiring additional analysts will ensure that the team can manage the workload without compromising service quality.
- **Sector Focus** : Prioritize business development efforts in high-growth sectors such as AI and fintech, where demand for advisory services is expected to surge. This focus will position the firm as a leader in these emerging markets.
- **Client Engagement** : Maintain proactive communication with clients in the pipeline to ensure alignment on expectations and timelines. Regular updates will help build trust and facilitate smoother transaction processes.

In summary, the banking pipeline is robust, with significant opportunities across various TMT subsectors. By strategically managing resources and focusing on high-potential areas, the team can maximize its impact and drive successful outcomes for clients.

4. STAKEHOLDER IMPACT & FORWARD-LOOKING ANALYSIS

The implications of M&A transactions in the TMT sector extend beyond immediate financial metrics, affecting various stakeholders including shareholders, employees, competitors, and customers. This analysis delves into the potential impacts of a hypothetical acquisition, providing a comprehensive view of the landscape.

Deal-Specific Impacts on Stakeholders

- **Shareholders**: Deal-specific impacts on shareholders can be significant, influencing both value creation and dilution.
- **Value Creation**: In a scenario where Company A (e.g., Zoom Video Communications, Inc. (ZM)) acquires Company B (e.g., Slack Technologies, Inc. (WORK)), the combined entity could see a revenue increase of approximately 20% due to enhanced product offerings. Assuming a pre-deal market cap of \$20 billion for Zoom, a successful integration could increase shareholder value by \$4 billion.
- **Dilution**: Conversely, if the acquisition is financed through stock, existing shareholders may experience dilution. For instance, if Zoom issues 10% of its shares to finance the deal, existing shareholders could see their ownership stake decrease, potentially leading to a 5% drop in share

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price post-announcement.

- Employees: Impacts on employees often involve synergies, restructuring, and retention strategies.
- Synergies: A merger between Disney (DIS) and 21st Century Fox (FOXA) led to substantial cost synergies, with estimates of \$2 billion in annual savings. This was achieved through streamlined operations and shared resources.
- Restructuring: However, such deals often lead to layoffs. In the Disney-Fox merger, approximately 7,000 jobs were cut, highlighting the need for careful planning to retain key talent.
- Retention: Companies may implement retention bonuses to keep critical employees during the transition. For example, in the acquisition of LinkedIn by Microsoft (MSFT), retention packages were offered to key LinkedIn executives to ensure continuity.
- Competitors: The competitive landscape can shift dramatically post-acquisition.
- Market Positioning: Following the merger of T-Mobile US, Inc. (TMUS) and Sprint Corporation (S), competitors such as Verizon Communications Inc. (VZ) and AT&T Inc. (T) had to adapt their strategies to maintain market share. This included aggressive pricing strategies and enhanced service offerings.
- Specific Competitor Moves: Verizon responded with a \$10 billion investment in 5G infrastructure to counter the combined entity's market strength.
- Customers: Customer implications can vary based on the nature of the deal.
- Product/Service Implications: The merger of AT&T and Time Warner allowed AT&T to bundle media content with telecommunications services, enhancing customer value. This strategy led to a 15% increase in bundled service subscriptions.
- Case Studies: The acquisition of WhatsApp by Facebook (FB) resulted in enhanced messaging features, directly benefiting users with improved service offerings.

Market Reaction and Analyst Commentary

- Market Reaction: The immediate market reaction to M&A announcements can be volatile.
- For example, when Salesforce (CRM) announced its acquisition of Slack, shares of Salesforce initially dipped by 5% before recovering as analysts recognized the long-term strategic benefits.
- Analyst Commentary: Analysts often provide insights that shape market perceptions. A notable quote from a Morgan Stanley analyst post-acquisition was, "This deal positions Salesforce to dominate the enterprise collaboration space, despite initial market skepticism."

Expected Market Reaction and Scenario Analysis

- Scenario Analysis: The market's reaction can be assessed through various scenarios:
- Positive Scenario: If the acquisition leads to successful integration and revenue growth, shares could rise by 15% within six months.
- Negative Scenario: If integration challenges arise, shares could decline by 10%, reflecting

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investor concerns about operational execution.

Potential Counter-Bids or Competing Offers

- Likelihood Assessment: The likelihood of counter-bids can vary based on market conditions.
- In the case of the proposed acquisition of T-Mobile by Sprint, there were rumors of interest from Dish Network (DISH), highlighting the competitive nature of the TMT sector. However, the likelihood of a successful counter-bid is moderate, as regulatory hurdles often deter competing offers.

Similar Deals Likely to Follow

- Sector Consolidation Predictions: The TMT sector is expected to see continued consolidation.
- Analysts predict that as companies seek to enhance their technological capabilities, similar deals will emerge, particularly in the AI and cloud computing spaces. Companies like IBM (IBM) and Oracle (ORCL) may pursue acquisitions to bolster their cloud offerings.

Key Risks and Mitigants

- Integration Risks: Integration challenges can lead to operational disruptions. Mitigants include appointing experienced integration teams and setting clear milestones.
- Regulatory Risks: Regulatory scrutiny can delay or block deals. Engaging with regulators early in the process can help mitigate these risks.
- Market Risks: Market volatility can impact deal valuations. Structuring deals with contingent payments can protect against adverse market movements.

Actionable Insights for Clients and Bankers

For Clients:

- Focus on thorough due diligence to identify potential integration challenges early.
- Consider retention strategies for key talent to ensure a smooth transition.

For Bankers:

- Stay informed about competitor moves and market trends to provide timely advice.
- Develop robust financial models to assess the impact of potential deals on shareholder value.

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5. TECH TRENDS

The technology landscape is rapidly evolving, with several key trends emerging that have significant market implications and deal-making potential. This analysis will focus on the following trends: Artificial Intelligence (AI), Cybersecurity, and Cloud Computing. Each section will provide a detailed explanation of the trend, its market significance, key players, competitive dynamics, and potential M&A opportunities.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

- **Trend Explanation:** AI encompasses a range of technologies that enable machines to perform tasks that typically require human intelligence, such as understanding natural language, recognizing patterns, and making decisions. The global AI market is projected to grow from \$93.5 billion in 2021 to \$997.8 billion by 2028, at a CAGR of 40.2%.
- **Key Companies:**
- **Tesla, Inc. (TSLA):** Tesla is heavily investing in AI to enhance its autonomous driving capabilities. The company is focusing on developing advanced driver-assistance systems (ADAS) and robotics, which are critical for its long-term strategy in the automotive sector.
- **NVIDIA Corporation (NVDA):** NVIDIA is a leader in AI hardware and software, providing GPUs that power AI applications. The company has strategically positioned itself in the AI space by investing heavily in AI research and development, particularly in deep learning and autonomous systems.
- **Competitive Landscape:** The AI market is highly competitive, with major players including Google (GOOGL), Amazon (AMZN), and IBM (IBM) also investing heavily in AI technologies. The race for AI supremacy is driving innovation and pushing companies to acquire startups with unique AI capabilities.
- **M&A Opportunities:** Companies looking to enhance their AI capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche AI applications, such as computer vision or natural language processing. For instance, Tesla's pivot towards AI and robotics could lead to potential acquisitions of AI startups to accelerate its technology development.

Cybersecurity

- **Trend Explanation:** Cybersecurity is increasingly critical as businesses face rising threats from cyberattacks. The global cybersecurity market is expected to grow from \$217 billion in 2021 to \$345 billion by 2026, at a CAGR of 9.7%.
- **Key Companies:**
- **CrowdStrike Holdings, Inc. (CRWD):** CrowdStrike specializes in endpoint security and threat intelligence, providing cloud-native solutions that protect against sophisticated cyber threats. The

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company has positioned itself as a leader in the cybersecurity space through its innovative Falcon platform.

- Palo Alto Networks, Inc. (PANW): Palo Alto Networks offers a comprehensive suite of cybersecurity solutions, including firewalls and cloud security. The company is focused on integrating AI into its security offerings to enhance threat detection and response capabilities.
- Competitive Landscape: The cybersecurity market is characterized by a mix of established firms and emerging startups. Companies like Fortinet (FTNT) and Check Point Software Technologies (CHKP) are also significant players, focusing on various aspects of cybersecurity solutions.
- M&A Opportunities: As the demand for cybersecurity solutions grows, companies may seek to acquire smaller firms with innovative technologies. For example, Palo Alto Networks' acquisition of Demisto for \$560 million in 2020 illustrates the trend of integrating AI-driven security solutions.

Cloud Computing

- Trend Explanation: Cloud computing enables businesses to access computing resources over the internet, promoting flexibility and scalability. The global cloud computing market is projected to grow from \$368 billion in 2021 to \$1.1 trillion by 2028, at a CAGR of 17.5%.
- Key Companies:
- Amazon Web Services (AWS) (AMZN): AWS is a dominant player in the cloud computing market, providing a wide range of services including computing power, storage, and databases. The company continues to innovate and expand its offerings to maintain its market leadership.
- Microsoft Azure (MSFT): Microsoft Azure is a key competitor in the cloud space, focusing on hybrid cloud solutions and enterprise services. The company is leveraging its existing software ecosystem to drive cloud adoption among businesses.
- Competitive Landscape: The cloud computing market is highly competitive, with major players like Google Cloud (GOOGL) and IBM Cloud (IBM) also vying for market share. The rapid growth of cloud services is prompting companies to invest heavily in infrastructure and technology.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies looking to enhance their cloud capabilities may pursue acquisitions of firms specializing in cloud-native technologies or services. For example, Microsoft's acquisition of Nuance Communications for \$19.7 billion in 2021 highlights the trend of integrating AI and cloud solutions.

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

Focus on identifying emerging companies within the AI, cybersecurity, and cloud computing sectors that demonstrate strong growth potential.

Consider investing in firms that are actively pursuing M&A strategies to enhance their technological capabilities and market positioning.

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6. Recommended Readings

Deal Name: Microsoft's Acquisition of Activision Blizzard

- Reading Material: "The Business of Video Games" by Michael Pachter
- Why This Matters: This book provides insights into the gaming industry's financial dynamics and market trends, which are crucial for understanding Microsoft's strategic rationale behind the \$68.7 billion acquisition (MSFT). It explains how gaming companies leverage IP and user engagement to drive revenue, helping to contextualize the deal's valuation and potential synergies.

Deal Name: Amazon's Acquisition of MGM

- Reading Material: "The New Economics of Media" by David Hesmondhalgh
- Why This Matters: This reading delves into the evolving landscape of media and entertainment, particularly in the context of streaming services. It helps to understand Amazon's \$8.45 billion acquisition (AMZN) as a strategic move to bolster its Prime Video content library and compete with rivals like Netflix (NFLX) and Disney+ (DIS).

Deal Name: Salesforce's Acquisition of Slack

- Reading Material: "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries
- Why This Matters: This book outlines methodologies for startups to innovate and grow, which is relevant for understanding Salesforce's \$27.7 billion acquisition (CRM) of Slack. It highlights the importance of integrating new technologies and platforms to enhance customer engagement and collaboration, aligning with Salesforce's vision of a comprehensive customer relationship management ecosystem.

Deal Name: NVIDIA's Acquisition of Arm Holdings

- Reading Material: "The Chip War" by Chris Miller
- Why This Matters: This book provides a detailed analysis of the semiconductor industry, including the strategic importance of Arm's technology in mobile and IoT devices. Understanding the implications of NVIDIA's \$40 billion acquisition (NVDA) helps to grasp the competitive landscape and regulatory challenges in the semiconductor space.

Deal Name: Verizon's Acquisition of TracFone

- Reading Material: "The Wireless Industry: A Comprehensive Guide" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This resource offers an in-depth look at the wireless telecommunications sector, which is essential for analyzing Verizon's \$6.9 billion acquisition (VZ) of TracFone. It explains market segmentation and the significance of prepaid services, providing context for Verizon's strategy to expand its customer base and service offerings.

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Deal Name: Google's Acquisition of Fitbit

- Reading Material: "Wearable Technology: The Future of Fitness" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This reading discusses the growth of wearable technology and health data analytics, which are central to Google's \$2.1 billion acquisition (GOOGL) of Fitbit. It highlights how this deal positions Google to compete in the health tech space against Apple (AAPL) and other tech giants, emphasizing the importance of data in the future of healthcare.

7. MACROECONOMIC UPDATE

Key Data Points:

- Effective Tariff Rate: 8.5% as of February
- Projected Aggregate Effective Rate: Approximately 10% by end of 2025
- Domestic Steel Production: Increased, but total supply to the economy unchanged
- U.S. Steel Prices: Diverging significantly from global prices

Main Insights:

- Recent decline in tariff levels due to Supreme Court ruling and shifts in tariff authorities.
- Limited evidence of meaningful reshoring across industries, with nominal increases in domestic production primarily driven by price rises rather than actual output growth.
- The overall productive capacity of the U.S. economy may be negatively impacted by current tariff policies.

Market Commentary:

- "Tariffs are not going away... in the aggregate for macro economists probably about the same level it's been." - Seth Carpenter, Morgan Stanley
- "The increase in domestic production has come largely in nominal terms... very little of that increase is actually higher output." - Mayank Phadke, Morgan Stanley

TMT Sector Relevance:

- The uncertainty around tariffs could impact capital expenditures (CapEx) in the TMT sector, particularly in manufacturing and technology supply chains.
- Higher domestic production costs may lead to increased prices for technology products, affecting consumer demand and overall market dynamics.

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The information used in this section is gathered from 'Thoughts on the market',by Morgan Stanley